

This is useful when you need to track changes on a daily or weekly basis, or if you'd rather have an alert in your inbox instead of subscribing to an entire newsletter. The frequency of the alert is a maximum of once a day. We'd like to see this alert feature integrated into Google Talk. But then we'd like a lot of features added to Google Talk!

Answer Me!!

Google Answers is one section that really got us interested. Google realised that people were willing to go through a lot of pain to get the answers they wanted. They hired a few hundred researchers who would comb the Net the entire day and collate and collect information. Please note that these are real people and not the bots that help Google turn out search results. So the aforementioned researchers sit around waiting for you to ask them questions. You also need to quote the price you are willing to pay for getting your question answered.

These researchers, who may or may not be experts in a particular field, will give you a detailed answer. The more complex the question, the more monies you need to put on the table.

Special searches for special needs, seems to be the credo that the search engine follows

search, or you could look in the directory given below. The Catalog search covers areas like clothing, computers and food. As we mentioned earlier, it makes more sense for US citizens, as most of the shops or suppliers do not ship overseas. But, then again, we Indians always have a cousin in the US who can order stuff for us, right?

Google's Directory search is the granddaddy of all searches. Web sites in these searches are indexed and given a specific page rank. You can browse through categories ranging from arts to health and sport. Each category is further divided into topics, which in turn may have sub-topics.

Though a little irritating, this categorisation gives precise search results.

Froogle is Google's attempt to set up an online bargain store directory. Again a very region specific search, Froogle claims to be the smart way to shop around your neighbourhood. You can look for shops in a specific area offering very good bargains, if you have a foreign trip planned and shopping figures high on your 'To-Do' list. As of now, this service is not available for shops outside the US, but Google plans to expand it to various countries soon.

Google Local search is yet another region specific service. Using Local search, you can actually zero in onto a particular shop or business in a city. The search throws up a list of shops or business that offers the service you requested, along with telephone numbers and addresses. But what really takes the cake is the map that turns up at the side actually pinpointing where the concerned business is. Even though there's nothing about India, it can be fun—for example, you can direct online friends to Tony's Pizza Pit in Poughkeepsie, New York, the next time they're hungry.

For Those Special Times

Special searches for special needs seems to be the credo that the search engine follows. A plethora of special searches can be performed by Google and you do not need to know how to optimise your subject details. Google offers targeted searches for operating systems such as Linux, BSD, Apple Macintosh and Microsoft Windows.

You can use it to find the latest updates and packages for Linux! Google also offers a University search that lets you look for a specific University, mostly in the US, and also directs you to the College's home page. This could be useful to students in India looking to apply to colleges abroad. Use it to plan your college education and get necessary details such as admissions information, course schedules, or alumni news, all minus unwanted search results.

Yet another US specific search is the US Government search. This service helps you snoop around all of Uncle Sam's government Web sites—including Federal as well as State Government sites. A search for Bechtel corporation threw up a few interesting results, including details of their involvement in India's Atomic programme.

Other search options, like Scholar search, bring up a number of research papers on the topic of your choice. This is extremely useful when you need to refer to such papers for work. You also get the contact information for the authors of these papers. Of course, most of these



An answer for all your questions is what Google Answers promises

You obviously do not need to pay until you get the answer from the researcher. Your question is also put up in a forum where other people looking for answers can take a peek at it and give you some unwelcome gyaan.

The service seems ideal for students who are looking up for something detailed to type out in their projects. You, however, should keep in mind that your questions are not necessarily answered by experts.

Devil In The Details

Google is essentially a search engine, Talk and GMail notwithstanding. Their expertise in search is acknowledged the world over, so it's obvious that they come up with a number of customised search services. Most of these, though, work for you only if you're in the US, UK, and in some other parts of Western Europe.

Their online Catalog service throws up results from various mail order shopping catalogues. You could search for a specific topic, like a normal